

Severity & Case Classification of Adverse Drug Reactions

Objective

To classify adverse drug reactions (ADRs) according to severity, seriousness and expectedness, and to evaluate their clinical impact using pharmacovigilance principles.

1. Severity Classification

Severity	Description	Clinical impact
Mild	Transient symptoms requiring little or no treatment and causing no or minimal discomfort or inconvenience. Usually self-limiting, observation or symptomatic treatment is usually sufficient.	
Moderate	Symptoms require treatment or a change in therapy and may interfere with normal activities. Moderate medical interventions or dose adjustment may be necessary.	
Severe	Intense or medically significant reaction requiring substantial treatment. High potential for long-term sequelae or hospitalization. High potential for emergency care or hospitalization.	

2. Seriousness Classification

An ADR is generally considered serious when it results in death, is life-threatening, requires or prolongs hospitalization, causes significant or persistent disability/incapacity, results in a congenital anomaly/birth defect, or is an important medical event requiring intervention to prevent a serious outcome.

3. Expectedness Classification

Classification	Meaning
Expected	The nature and severity of the reaction are consistent with the applicable product information/reference safety information.
Unexpected	The nature, severity, specificity or outcome is not consistent with the applicable product information/reference safety information.

4. Evaluation of Multiple Cases

Case	Scenario	Severity	Serious?	Expectedness	Clinical impact
1	Mild nausea after an oral medicine; resolves with supportive care.	Mild	No	Expected*	Low
2	Severe bronchospasm requiring emergency treatment and hospitalization.	Severe	Yes	Expected/Unexpected*	High; potentially life-threatening
3	Serious skin reaction requiring hospitalization and no debridement.	Severe	Yes	Unexpected*	Very high; urgent management
4	Dizziness causing temporary difficulty walking; resolves with dose adjustment.	Moderate	No	Expected*	Moderate; therapy modification needed

*Expectedness must be confirmed against the applicable product information/reference safety information for the suspected medicine.

5. Clinical Impact

- **Low:** self-limiting symptoms with minimal effect on treatment or patient status.
- **Moderate:** requires additional treatment, monitoring, dose adjustment or temporary interruption.
- **High:** requires emergency treatment, hospitalization, intensive monitoring or may be life-threatening.
- **Critical:** death, permanent disability, congenital anomaly, or another major medically important outcome.

6. Conclusion

Severity describes the intensity of an ADR, while seriousness is determined by clinically and regulatory significant outcomes. Expectedness is determined by comparison with the applicable reference safety information. Correct classification supports patient management, safety reporting, signal detection and pharmacovigilance decision-making.